

Anna Dinius's TA Artifact: Important Information

This document contains a brief explanation of the contribution I chose to submit for my TA artifact.

Reasoning

Dr. Cho recently reworked all the course materials for ASE 285: Software Engineering and Security Fundamentals. However, a couple of the new documents he created to teach students about Software Engineering are incredibly long. There are three documents in particular, one that is 145 pages long, one that is 180 pages long, and one that is 350 pages long. Because of the length, I do not believe the students actually read through any of them. However, those documents contain important information they need to know for the class. So, as my TA artifact, I reworked the 145-page document (`se_and_ase_courses.pdf`) and condensed the lessons down into a 10-page document.

Process

Because I used AI to assist me with creating this artifact, I want to share my process so I can be completely transparent about how and why I used it.

Dr. Cho is a huge proponent of AI. He encourages all of his students to take advantage of it in his classes and frequently uses it himself (of course, he encourages **proper** use). Before beginning work on this artifact, I met with Dr. Cho, and he gave approval for my proposal of not only the artifact but also the use of AI to assist in its creation.

I used the AI agents built into the Cursor IDE.

I gave the AI access to the original document (`se_and_ase_courses.pdf`) along with the following prompt:

I am a teaching assistant for a college-level software engineering course. The `se_and_ase_courses.pdf` doc contains the original documentation created by the professor. It is in the form of a story with conversations between characters. The point of the doc is to teach students the lessons within the conversations about software engineering. However, the doc is too long and most if not all students don't actually read the doc because of the length. I need you to compile the lessons and takeaways into the `takeaways.md` doc. Make sure they are comprehensive, but do not use the conversation style of the original doc. Organize and write the lessons/takeaways in a way that is easy for college students to understand. The takeaways should be organized/designed in such a way that students can easily find what they need and understand the concepts. Choose the format (marp or markdown) that you think is best. Do not refer to any outside sources. Add citations throughout the takeaways to cite which part of the `se_and_ase_courses.pdf` each one came from.

The original document generated by the AI (`takeaways.md`) can be found on my GitHub repository.

Next, I read through the document the AI generated to make some small wording and spacing changes and add emphasis.

Then, I went through each section of the document and compared it with the content on the cited pages of the source material. As I compared the two, I modified the AI's document to add clarification, expand definitions, and add critical information and images that the AI missed.

The original document (`se_and_ase_courses.pdf`) and my final student guide document (`student-guide-to-SE.pdf`) can also be found on my GitHub repository.